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HINDU POLITICAL THEOLOGY: BEYOND HINDUTVA'S POLITICAL MONOTHEISM

Abstract

This paper, presented in December 2023 at the "Religious Origins of White Supremacy: Johnson v. M'Intosh and the Doctrine of Christian Discovery" conference at Syracuse University, analyzes the rise of Hindutva, or Hindu nationalism, through the framework of 'political theology' that was developed in the early 20th century by the German jurist Carl Schmitt. In the essay, I explore the ways that Hindutva ideology invokes political–theological concepts to construct a unitary 'Hindu' identity that is conceived not only in religious terms, but in racial and civilizational terms as well. I draw upon Schmitt's conception of political theology, as well as the work of scholars such as Anustup Basu who have characterized Hindutva as a form of 'political monotheism' due to its central project of flattening and homogenizing the incredibly diverse array of practices and traditions that fall under the 'Hindu' umbrella in service of an exclusionary, ethnic and cultural nationalist political project. In order to resist this 'political monotheism,' the essay argues for a return to an expansive understanding of what 'Hindu' means, and for the decoupling of "Hindu–ness" from nationhood in favor of a more syncretic and inclusive conception of Indian national identity.

Keywords*: Hinduism, Hindutva, Hindu nationalism, religious nationalism, Hindu identity*

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Just a few days ago, December 6th, marked the thirty–first anniversary of the Babri Masjid demolition, in which a mob consisting of tens of thousands of Hindu nationalist militants descended on a 16th–century mosque in the North Indian city of Ayodhya and tore down the historic structure, which they alleged had been constructed by the Mughal emperor Babur on the site of a demolished Hindu temple. The demolition sparked horrific communal rioting across India which left thousands, mostly Muslims, dead, including 900 people in the city of Bombay alone.

Many observers agree that the 'Ram Janmabhoomi' movement in the early 1990s, which called for a temple honoring the Hindu deity Ram to be established on the site of the Babri Masjid, and which culminated in the mosque's demolition, marked a turning point for the Hindutva, or Hindu nationalist movement, which has since risen to political hegemony in India over the last three decades. Represented in the Indian government by the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and in international civil society by the RSS paramilitary and its "Sangh Parivar" network of Hindu nationalist organizations, the Hindutva movement holds as its primary goal the transformation of India from a secular, pluralistic liberal democracy into a majoritarian Hindu ethnostate where Muslims and other marginalized minorities are treated as second–class citizens.

However, while the 1992 Babri demolition was certainly a primary catalyst for the Hindutva movement's political ascendancy, this moment did not occur in a vacuum. Rather, as Bishnupriya Ghosh argues, "1992 was not an aberration but the long historical denouement of the idea of India as organically the land of the Hindus."[2] In order, therefore, to understand the rise of the Hindu nationalist movement in the more than three decades since the Babri Masjid's demolition, it is important to understand the history and evolution of the Hindutva ideology that underpins this movement. In this paper, I will attempt to trace an outline of the political theology of Hindutva across multiple dimensions, emphasizing its fundamentally monotheistic nature, before finally raising the question of how we might resist Hindutva's political monotheism.

Hindutva as Political Monotheism

The term "Hindutva" was first used in the 1890s by the Bengali writer Chandranath Basu, who sought to defend "traditional" Hindu practices against the growing efforts of contemporary reform movements.[3] As an ideological framework, however, Hindutva's key tenets were first articulated in 1922 by the right–wing ideologue V.D. Savarkar, in his pamphlet Hindutva: Who is a Hindu?[4] It was this text, alongside others such as M.S. Golwalkar's 1939 work We, or Our Nationhood Defined, that served as one of the foundational manifestos of the Hindu nationalist movement, and its core ideas continue to feature prominently in contemporary Hindutva politics to this day.

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[2] Bishnupriya Ghosh, "The Making of the Hindu Normative," *Boundary 2* 50, no. 2 (2023): 211–22, https://doi.org/10.1215/01903659-10300679.

[3] Chetan Bhatt, *Hindu Nationalism: Origins, Ideologies and Modern Myths*, 1st ed. (Routledge, 2020), https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003085553.

[4] Also published under the title Essentials of Hindutva.

But what does the word "Hindu" really mean? Unlike other traditions which are defined by adherence to a common scripture or set of doctrinal beliefs, the word 'Hindu' does not refer to such a clearly––demarcated religion—in fact, many have trouble even locating Hinduism within the framework of "religion" at all. There is no one Hindu holy book, nor is there a single Hindu prophet or a central Hindu church. Rather, "Hindu" is an umbrella term encompassing a vast and extraordinarily diverse constellation of philosophical, spiritual, and religious traditions emerging out of the Indian subcontinent. These traditions vary widely across both time and geography, influencing and building upon and not infrequently contradicting one another, to the point that one might very well say that there are as many Hinduisms as there are Hindus—if not more. And yet, as an ideology of religious nationalism, Hindutva seeks to construct a unified national––religious community—a project which necessarily entails flattening and homogenizing this rich internal diversity. This has led the scholar Anustup Basu, in a 2020 book, to describe Hindutva as a form of what he calls "political monotheism."

This characterization, though perhaps at odds with popular (mis)conceptions of Hinduism as a polytheistic tradition, is one that I am inclined to agree with. It comes from Basu's reading of the concept of "political theology" elaborated by the Nazi jurist Carl Schmitt, a concept which Basu argues is fundamentally monotheistic in nature. Schmitt's concept of political theology can be best summed up by his famous assertion that "all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts,"[5] Basu contends that this "Schmittian notion of the political" is "a fundamentally monotheistic calling, not just a religious or theological one in a general, multicultural sense," because it entails "a singular impelling of devotion to the nation and the state."[6]

Having thus drawn out this "tacit monotheistic imperative."[7] Basu applies the framework of political monotheism to Hindutva, arguing that the movement's early ideologues were faced with the challenge of constructing a unitary national–religious Hindu identity from an almost infinitely diverse and heterogeneous landscape of spiritual beliefs, religious practices, and caste communities. This meant, in Basu's words, "finding a pan–Indian congregational principle to subsume long–standing caste divisions, regional eccentricities, gender segregations, and practices of untouchability," in order to construct "an axiomatic Church and a sense of Hindu laity that could then be parlayed into the political construction of a national fraternité."[8]

At the theological level, this homogenizing project is exemplified by the Hindu nationalist movement's adoption of the deity Ram, central protagonist of the epic Ramayan, as an "axiomatic Hindu icon"[9] who has, as the political scientist Paul Brass has argued, "become the political emblem of the RSS family of organizations."[10] This includes the highest levels of Indian political leadership—in his August 2020 speech at the foundation––laying ceremony for the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, for example, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi declared that "Ram is etched in our souls, we have internalised him, everybody looks up to him…he is the basis of our culture, he represents Indian virtues." The slogan "Jai Shri Ram" ("Victory to Lord

[5] Carl Schmitt, *Political Theology: Four Chapters on the Concept of Sovereignty*, trans. George Schwab (University of Chicago Press, 2005), 36.

[6] A Basu, *Hindutva as Political Monotheism* (Duke University Press, 2020), 14.

[7] Bhatt, *Hindu Nationalism*.

[8] Schmitt, *Political Theology: Four Chapters on the Concept of Sovereignty*.

[9] Ibid.

[10] Paul R. Brass, *The Production of Hindu-Muslim Violence in Contemporary India* (University of Washington Press, 2011), 365.

Ram") has been adopted as a rallying cry by Hindu nationalist mobs, who often force the victims of their attacks to chant the phrase,[11] and annual religious observances of the Ram Navami festival, which celebrates the deity's birth, have been transformed in recent years from small–scale local celebrations into "an opportunity for the Hindu right–wing to intimidate and assert their dominance over the Muslim community" through religious violence and inflammatory processions through Muslim neighborhoods.[12]

Hindutva and the construction of Hindu national identity

It's worth highlighting here as well the monotheistic implications of the term 'Hindutva' itself, and the way that it is invoked by the Hindu nationalist movement. The term 'Hindutva' comes from modern Sanskrit, and is often translated as "Hindu–ness"—i.e., the essential state or quality of being Hindu.[13] Implicit in the definition of Hindutva as "Hindu–ness," however, is the assumption that it is possible in the first place to discern such a fundamental Hindu essence. Of course, this implicit assumption seems difficult to square with the full diversity of communities and practices that actually fall under the "Hindu" umbrella—in the face of such heterogeneity, any attempt to define the "essence" of what it means to be Hindu must necessarily erase or obscure the multiplicity of the Hindu tradition, or else be so broad as to be functionally useless for the purposes of nationalist identity construction.

In practice, as I highlighted before, the understanding of Hindu religion advanced by this movement is very much limited, in the "monotheistic" sense described by Basu, to a certain narrow conception of Hindu religious practice.[14] On an ideological level, however, it's interesting to note that the idea of "Hindutva" invoked by the likes of Savarkar does not limit itself to any one religious practice––in Essentials of Hindutva, Savarkar writes that "when we attempt to investigate into the essential significance of Hindutva we do not primarily—and certainly not mainly—concern ourselves with any particular theocratic or religious dogma or creed."[15]

So what exactly does Savarkar mean, then, by "Hindu"? In order to define the term for the purposes of nationalist identity mobilization, Savarkar conceptualizes "Hindu–ness" in racial and civilizational, rather than explicitly religious, terms. Savarkar's text is littered with references to the "Hindu race," and he defines a Hindu as someone for whom the Indian subcontinent is both a "Fatherland" and a "Holyland." A Hindu, for Savarkar, is one "who inherits the blood of that race …[which] has come to be known as the Hindu people, who has inherited and claims as his own the culture of that race…and who above all, addresses this land…as his Holyland (Punyabhu), as the land of his prophets and seers, of his godmen and

[11] Shoaib Daniyal, "'Jai Shri Ram' Might Be a New Slogan – but the Use of Ram as a Political Symbol Is 800 Years Old," Scroll.In, June 28, 2019, https://scroll.in/article/928508/from-ayodhya-to-parliament-a-very-short-history-of-jai-shri-ram.

[12] Rashid Khan, "How India's Ram Navami Processions Are Used to Enflame Religious Polarization," The Diplomat, April 27, 2023, https://thediplomat.com/2023/04/how-indias-ram-navami-processions-are-used-to-%20enflame-religious-polarization/.

[13] This translation, I should note, is often invoked by Hindutva supporters as a defense against criticisms of Hindutva, on the grounds that such criticisms are in fact "Hinduphobic" in their supposed targeting of "Hindu–ness."

[14] One that is typically rooted in dominant-caste Brahminical norms, as evidenced by Hindutva's privileging of vegetarianism through ostracization and even violence against those who eat meat—many of whom come from oppressed caste communities.

[15] Vinayak Damodar, *Savarkar, Hindutva; Who Is a Hindu*, 5th ed. (Veer Savarkar Prakashan, 1969), 3–4.

gurus, the land of piety and pilgrimage. These are the essentials of Hindutva—a common nation (Rashtra), a common race (Jati), and a common civilization (Sanskriti)."[16]

Here, then, we see the recasting of "Hindu–ness" not as an umbrella concept denoting a vast and diverse set of spiritual traditions, but rather as a racial and civilizational category of which religion is only one small dimension. The significance of this cannot be overstated—it is precisely through this reconceptualization that a Hindu nationalist politics is made possible, as the term "Hindu" is no longer merely a broad descriptor, but rather becomes the name of a discrete community identity that can be mobilized in service of a nationalist political agenda. Implicit in Savarkar's racial and civilizational conception of Hindu identity is the idea that Hindus are the true "indigenous" Indians, in contrast to non–Hindu "outsiders" or "invaders"—a notion of Hindu indigeneity that the Hindutva movement is then able to invoke when laying exclusionary nationalist claims to the entire territory of the Indian subcontinent.

And this is precisely what they have done. It's important to note that while Savarkar's civilizational framework includes Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists within the Hindu fold—a logic of appropriation that the Hindutva movement still invokes to this day—it explicitly excludes Muslims and Christians, despite these communities' centuries–long roots in the Indian subcontinent. "That is why," Savarkar writes,

in the case of some of our Mohammedan or Christian countrymen who…have inherited along with Hindus, a common Fatherland and a greater part of the wealth of a common culture…[they] are not and cannot be recognized as Hindus. For though Hindusthan to them is Fatherland as to any other Hindu yet it is not to them a Holyland too. Their holy land is far off in Arabia or Palestine. Their mythology and Godmen, ideas and heroes are not the children of this soil. Consequently their names and their outlook smack of a foreign origin. Their love is divided.[17]

In other words, the very idea of a "Hindu" national or civilizational community as conceptualized within Hindutva ideology was explicitly intended from the outset to exclude other groups such as Christians and in particular Muslims, who are instead juxtaposed as foreign "invaders" against the "indigenous" Hindu inhabitants of the subcontinent.

This is reflected in the ways that Hindu nationalists to this day talk about Indian history, framing the timeline of the subcontinent's colonization as beginning not with the arrival of European powers in the 17th century, but rather with much earlier conquests by Muslim empires. As the scholar of medieval South Asia Audrey Truschke puts it: "In Hindutva history—oxymoron though that phrase is—premodern India had two major phases: a glorious Hindu golden age followed by an era of Muslim oppression of Hindus."[18] In the aftermath of the Babri Masjid's demolition, Indian historian Gyanendra Pandey examined the histories of Ayodhya that were proliferating in Hindu nationalist circles, sold at roadside stalls and pilgrimage sites, which portrayed the "Ram Janmabhoomi" movement as the culmination of a centuries–long struggle between barbaric Muslim invaders and brave defenders of the Hindu faith, centering on the disputed site of the Babri Masjid.[19]

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[16] Damodar, *Savarkar, Hindutva; Who Is a Hindu*, 115–16.

[17] Damodar, *Savarkar, Hindutva; Who Is a Hindu*, 114.

[18] Audrey Truschke, "Hindutva's Dangerous Rewriting of History," *South Asia Multidisciplinary Academic Journal*, no. 24/25 (December 2020): 4, 24/25, https://doi.org/10.4000/samaj.6636.

[19] Truschke, "Hindutva's Dangerous Rewriting of History," 4.

Thus, the foundations are laid for Hindutva's particular form of political monotheism. As Anustup Basu points out, the "unitary impelling of the political" in Carl Schmitt's conception of political theology requires what he calls a "monotheme of identity"—the political, Basu writes, "must birth a concomitant religiosity that could be based on race, on ideological world view…or on ethnicities of various kinds. The citizen is, ultimately, an acolyte who requires an overt or covert ontotheology to worship the state and identify enemies."[20] The "monotheme of identity" for Hindutva's monotheistic political theology, then, is precisely this ancient and existential struggle between the Hindu nation and its Muslim enemy. To be a Hindu, within the framework of Hindutva's monotheistic political theology, is to devote oneself completely to the Hindu nationalist cause, and therefore to this struggle. As Basu puts it: "the nation can be achieved in its true essence only if the Hindu is allowed to settle very old scores with primal enemies."[21]

Conclusion: Beyond Hindutva's political monotheism

Thus far, I have attempted to sketch out an overview of Hindutva's political theology, emphasizing its fundamentally monotheistic nature. But where do we go from here? The current situation in India, where the Hindutva movement enjoys a completely unprecedented degree of social, political, and cultural hegemony, highlights more than ever the need to resist Hindutva's political monotheism. But what form might such resistance take?

The answer, I think, lies in the total and unequivocal rejection of any attempt to tie Hinduism to a national identity at all. We should be able to state clearly that the mere fact that Hinduism originated in the Indian subcontinent does not, in and of itself, mean that Hindus are the subcontinent's "true" indigenous inhabitants, nor does it mean that Hindus therefore have an exclusive claim on Indian national identity. The Indian identity has always been a syncretic one, fundamentally shaped by cultural, religious, linguistic, and political influences from the countless communities that have lived in, migrated through, invaded, traded with, and encountered the subcontinent. And above all, it is an identity whose contours were shaped and sharpened by the experience of two centuries of British colonial rule—an experience that was shared every bit as much by Muslims, Sikhs, and Christians as it was by Hindus.

In conclusion, to reject Hindutva's political monotheism is to reject the Hindutva project altogether. There is, simply put, no way for a narrowly–defined Hindu national identity and a more expansive, inclusive, and syncretic Indian national identity to coexist. For the former identity to take root, as is the goal of the Hindutva movement, the latter identity must be subsumed, erased, and even denied altogether. This is why I argue that in order to reject Hindutva's political monotheism, it is necessary to reject the politics of Hindu nationalism—or in other words, to reject the very idea of Hindu nationhood itself. To do otherwise is to reify the hateful, exclusionary, supremacist politics that the Hindutva movement has long sought, with an alarming degree of success, to advance.

[20] Basu, *Hindutva as Political Monotheism*, 16.

[21] Basu, *Hindutva as Political Monotheism*.